

“Learning to wear a mask (that word already embedded in the term ‘masculinity’) is the first lesson in patriarchal masculinity that a boy learns. He learns that his core feelings cannot be expressed if they do not conform to the acceptable behaviors sexism defines as male. Asked to give up the true self in order to realize the patriarchal ideal, boys learn self-betrayal early and are rewarded for these acts of soul murder.”

Bell Hooks, *The Will to Change*

Youth football



We'd show up early, so I'd sit on the highway guardrail around the outside of the field, waiting for my teammates to arrive and trying my best to hold back the tears I usually let flow on the drive over to the field. I hoped to spark something in the parent driving me to the field that day. Maybe they'd let me skip just one day of football practice.

While waiting I'd imagine myself sitting at the dinner table later that night — how relieved I'd be that the day's work was done, that I had a 24-hour break until the next round. 2 hours of practice was all that stood between me and that feeling at the dinner table, but also Grapes. It was the conditioning drill we'd usually end practice with. Four cones in a square each about 20 yards apart. Coach Pack would blow the whistle and we'd start jogging around the square. On his second whistle we'd start sprinting, on the next we could return to a jog. The jog-sprint sequence continued until he'd had enough, usually when my teammate Joey started dry heaving. Coach Pack loved Grapes.

As his red F-150 would pull into the park I'd put my helmet on and start the walk from the guardrail over to the field. If he saw my face up close he'd probably notice the crybaby face.

I dreaded football as a young boy, but my dad worked hard to keep me encouraged. He'd remind me it would eventually get easier, that I'd even learn to love the sport, which he was right about. But it took about eight more years for that love to develop, meanwhile, my helmet was useful for hiding lots of tears.

College football



At 5:30 I'd snap awake to the sound of my alarm, trying to catch it before the ring woke up my roommate. I'd throw on some layers and head out the door, unlock my bike and start the journey to the locker room. The fall weather in northeastern Ohio wasn't gentle, especially at that time of day — cold and wet. The bike ride to the field was similar to that wait on the guardrail before practices with Coach Pack. I'd spend the time daydreaming about what I'd be doing post-practice. I'd be feeling the same sense of relief I did as a child at the dinner table, this time sitting in the dining hall with my teammates for lunch, how thankful I'd be for a 24-hour break from the field.

As we got dressed for practice my teammates would pass around the pre-workout, trying to get the juices flowing before coach's first whistle at 6:40. He worked to combat our lack of energy at that time by starting every practice with a 15-minute, full-contact scrimmage. If the pre-workout wasn't doing the trick to wake us up for practice, maybe some head-on-head collisions would.

Our team was bad, with a few winless seasons in recent history. Most losses were lopsided. But every week, one day after our latest loss, we'd show up to team meetings on Monday with some enthusiasm, excited to get a new scouting report and game plan, eager to forget that latest defeat. We didn't acknowledge the pattern that was forming — that another loss was probably waiting for us at the end of this week too.

I struggled to hold onto what it was that I loved about football, hitting people. Football had become an outlet for some aggression that started to develop in high school. My aggression was more useful on the field than my tears. I looked forward to chances to deliver violent hits in game, usually not even tracking the lopsided score. My favorite football memories were standing up after one of those hits, seeing the recipient of the hit unable to do the same. His teammates would gather around to check his status, then call to the sideline for the trainer. I always felt so proud in those moments.

In college, the type of violent hits I liked most started getting penalized, as the safety of the sport

began to be scrutinized. I got less and less playing time, our team lost more and more games, and again, I found myself considering quitting. I'd talk it over with dad, who I knew still loved watching me play. He knew I wasn't enjoying it like I once had. But I think we both wondered if things may turn around if I could just push through the discomfort. It happened before when I was a younger player. If I could just stick with it, college football would become fun for me too, as had football in my younger years.

After games dad and I would spend time recapping my favorite hits of the day, laughing together over the most violent, a tradition started back in high school. During one of those post-game recaps my sophomore year at Oberlin I noticed a yellow tinge in his eyes. I asked if he was feeling alright, if something was wrong with his eyes, "Just a little dry from the wind." A couple weeks later we found out he had stage 4 cancer. After his diagnosis, he told the doctor about some symptoms that he'd had for a few years. My family didn't know about any of them. He was pushing through something himself.

Football showed me how to be a man. In my football pads I grew from the young boy crying on the guardrail before practice to something more masculine – an aggressive, violent player, who liked to hit and hurt others. For me this transition is easily seen through the lens of football. But at its core this isn't an uncommon transition among all boys becoming men, however it may manifest. We leave behind the emotional, vulnerable boy we once were for a new version of ourselves that's better-suited for the world around us as we age.

Breakfast dates



We parked dad's new (used) red F-150 in the handicap spot and made our way inside for our weekly post-chemo brunch. This week — coffee and donuts. We were about 5 back from the register so had plenty of time to eye our choices. Probably a blueberry cake and apple fritter for me. Dad usually went for a Boston cream and an old fashioned. But this time when we got to the register he just turned to me for my order — nothing for him today.

We got ourselves waters and found a seat. All the edge tables were taken so we sat at a table out in the middle of the cafe floor, feeling exposed. We each got out our phones, checked for messages. He texted Mom to let her know we'd finished at the hospital and be home in a couple

hours.

I don't remember all of what we covered in our conversation over breakfast that day. A majority of the time was probably spent by me getting his advice on things like my upcoming semester of courses, dating, and my plans for after grad school. We'd talk about the morning's conversation with his doctor, how treatment was feeling. Those days the latest chemo side effect was mouth sores. They'd bust open anytime he ate. That's why he'd passed on donuts today.

I remember the last topic of conversation that day. He told me he wasn't sure how much longer he wanted to keep getting treatment for his cancer, which wasn't a surprise. It had all gone on much longer than anticipated. But what caught me off guard was when he told me he wasn't sure how he could tell mom. He asked for my advice. I had none. We tried our best to hold back tears, sitting there in the middle of the cafe. I told him we all loved him.

That was the most vulnerable I'd ever seen him. Even as his body broke down, up to that point he'd made a point to let us know his mind and will were still intact, his toughness still there at his core. In that moment I was uncomfortable, but grateful. I felt like I hadn't said enough in reply. Looking back, I failed to meet him in his vulnerability. I wasn't able to match him. That's not an unusual feeling.



Sluggers

After a lap around Herbert Von King I find a parking spot, unload the gear from my truck and walk over to the field. A few players are usually already waiting for me on the bleachers. To my frustration, others usually stroll in 15-30 minutes late.

These days I'm the coach, of 10-year old baseball players in Bed-Stuy Brooklyn. They struggle to pay attention as I give direction. I struggle to maintain my composure when they aren't fully adopting my 2-strike hitting philosophy. I wonder if they'll remember me like I remember Coach

Pack and the others.

They still cry after errors and strikeouts. I call their moms in the dugout for help when it happens. But I hope sooner than me they learn all these feelings are best not hidden, that maybe it's alright to show the world something closer to their full selves — even teary-eyed.

Eventually their performance on the diamond won't hurt them so deeply, but in the meantime, I'll hold back the first words that come to mind when they meet me in the dugout with eyes watering: "You're fine, stop crying."

If I can stop telling it to myself, I wonder.